

RADIO MEDICAL

Medicine and first aid - presentation

The aim of this written assignment is to get used to finding information either in *International Medical Guide for ships* (WHO, Geneva 1988 or newer) or *The Ship Captain's Medical Guide*, available in the Internet:

http://www.mcga.gov.uk/c4mca/mcga-seafarer_information/mcga-dqs_st_shs_seafarer_information-medical/mcga-dqs_st_shs_ships_capt_medical_guide.htm

You should choose one of the topics from the list below and write a short presentation. E-mail the paper to your teacher. If the topics are presented in class the classmates should take notes of the main parts while listening (and ask questions where needed). The notes are then discussed and checked by the teacher.

The list of topics:

1. Hypothermia
2. Head injuries
3. Shock
4. Burns and scalds
5. Eye injuries
6. Poisoning
7. Asthma
8. Heat-stroke
9. Epilepsy
10. Severe bleeding
11. Fractures
12. Near-drowning

Radio Medical - Find the synonyms (the text)

Radio Medical is an advanced medical consultation service by telephone, telegraphy or by other communication means, where a specially trained doctor makes a diagnosis, prescribes medicine, and gives advice and instructions about the treatment of the patient onboard. In the case of an emergency he makes the decision about evacuation if the ship's position allows it. Sometimes Radio Medical advice can be obtained from another ship in the vicinity carrying a doctor onboard. It is better to exchange information in a language common to both parties. However, in many cases English is used.

Every hour, every day throughout the year there must be a doctor available who can assist the seafarers, even if he does not meet the patients face to face.

When should Radio Medical be used? The officer responsible for medical care onboard must not hesitate to contact Radio Medical, even if it is a matter of a simple question about the contents of a medicine. On a scale ranging from 'moderately ill' through 'ill' to 'very ill' then 'seriously ill', contact with a doctor should be made when the patient's condition is somewhere between 'moderately ill' and 'ill'.

A vessel in port is allowed to make contact with Radio Medical only if the assistance cannot be obtained by any other means.

Before making contact with the e.g. desired MRCC or radio station in order to be transferred to the doctor the following information should be compiled:

- Use the special medical report form for consultation with a doctor from the ship (or a similar form) and check the general condition of the patient's temperature, pulse and respiration, results from the tests taken etc.
- Name of ship, call sign, contact numbers, course, speed, position, port of destination, nearest port and other relevant information.
- The contents of your medical chest; type of drugs and equipment onboard.
- Patient's name, sex, age and rank. Under certain circumstances it is recommended to withhold the name (and rank) to preserve confidentiality. This information can be added later to complete the doctor's record.

- In the case of illness: when and how the illness first began. In the case of injury: when exactly the injury arose. Make a list of complaints and symptoms.
- Give possible past illnesses, injuries and operations where relevant.
- Have a list of all the treatments and medicines given and how the patient responded.

Give the relevant information and write down any advice you receive. Repeat the information back to avoid any misunderstandings. If you can record the information, it could be played back later to clarify written notes. It is important that all the information, advice and directives are clearly understood.

Despite modern telecommunications many medical officers verify that it is still the basic things that let them down: merchant ships do not stock the recommended drugs or when they do they are out of date. Lack of proper equipment is another reason for failing to give proper medical care.

An interview with a doctor who has worked for Radio Medical

Text as a background

"Radio Medical Advice"

Radio Medical Advice is available, by radio telegraphy, or by direct radio-telephonic contact with the doctor, from a number of ports in all parts of the world. It may, on occasion, be obtained from another ship in the vicinity which has a doctor on board. In either instance, it is better if the exchange of information is in a language common to both parties. Coded messages are a frequent source of misunderstandings and should be avoided as far as possible.

It is very important that *a//*the information possible should be passed on to the doctor and that *a//*his advice and directives should be clearly understood and fully recorded. A comprehensive set of notes should be ready to be passed on to the doctor, preferably based on the format given on pages..." **International Medical Guide for Ships. 1988 WHO Geneva**

The transcript

(Introduction)

Q. Can you introduce yourself?

A. My name is Karin Mattsson, and I am a coordinator at the Swedish Radio Medical Department at Sahlgrenska University hospital.

Q. How long have you been working for Radio Medical in Sweden?

A. I have been working as a coordinator at the Swedish Radio Medical Department at Sahlgrenska University hospital since 1996. Well...the RM center at the hospital is national, as you probably know, but we also work with international cases all over the world.

(Contacts)

Q. Which nationalities have the vessels you worked with represented - I mean which flags have they had?

A. Most of them have Swedish flags.. er.. I think 60-70 % are actually Swedish. The rest come from all different countries.



Education and Culture

Leonardo da Vinci

Q. Which are the common means of communication used for contacting a doctor at Radio Medical, for example, have they contacted you by VHF, radio telegraphy or by other channels?

A. The most common ways to contact us is by telephone , via satellite of course. The next is fax but communication by e-mail is growing and becoming more and more common... that is something that has changed recently.

Q. Where have the vessels been situated when they have contacted you?

A. I must say that we have cases from all over the world... but of course ..erm ..the majority of vessels which contact us come from nearby areas ..I mean..approximately 2 out of 3 cases come from the Baltic Sea, Kattegat Skagerak and the North Sea.

(FAQs)

Q. What is the most common piece of advice you have given?

A. I think almost 15 % of the cases are about some kind of pain in the abdominal region and 15 % are respiratory tract infections. Well.. er ..these are definitely the two biggest groups. Then comes musculo-skeletal pains .. backpain is excluded here.. various accidents followed by eye and teeth problems, and then..finally I could mention back- and chest-pains. Quite a variety of advice to give! Certainly, there are many kinds of problems I haven't even mentioned here, but, but they are not as frequent as the ones I mentioned.

Q.What is the normal result after consulting a doctor.. for example does it often lead to an evacuation by helicopter?

A. Well, as far as the figures are concerned...almost 70 % receive full treatment onboard, which is good. 10-15 % will see a doctor in next the scheduled port and around 10-15% lead to evacuation by helicopter or another vessel.

Q. Have you ever been online and conducted for example an operation? - And how often does online guidances take place?

A. Well online guidance does take place from time to time.. but as for operations - they are extremely rare.

(Communications)

Q. Have you experienced any communication problems with seafarers? If so, what kind of problems?

A. As a matter of fact not very often. Sometimes we have had difficulties in communication with vessels due to their lack of knowledge in English or because of a bad telephone connection.

Q. And my last question: how frequently do people make contact with Radio Medical?

A. Quite frequently...in fact we have consultations practically every day. The Swedish Radio Medical department handled 450 cases during 2004 which meant several contacts per day.

Q. Is there anything else you think seafarers should know about using Radio Medical?

A. Yes sure, there are many things but - I think the most important thing is to know When to take contact Why and How, but also What should I measure.. I mean..what kind of information should I gather before I call Radio Medical.

(Conclusion)

Thank you Karin Mattsson! We really appreciate you taking the time to answer our questions!